4.2 Charity (Zakāh)

OBJECTIVES

WE WILL:

- Understand and investigate the connection between prayer *(ṣalāh)* and charity *(zakāh)*.
- Define *zakāh* as meaning purification, and as the general term used in the Qurʾān for being charitable.
- Establish *zakāh* as a means of purification, a loan to Allah ﷻ, and trading with Allah ﷻ for something higher.
- Outline different forms of charity, such as through education, helping others, and with one's wealth.
- Define *khums* as literally meaning 'one-fifth' which involves giving one-fifth (20%) of our savings and unused items at the end of one year.
- Compare the rewards of meeting the needs of fellow believers to the highest rewards in Islam; and understand that benefiting others and removing harm from their path are also considered forms of charity.

Allah ﷻ says in the Qurʾān:

قُلْ لِعِبَادِيَ الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا يُقِيمُوا الصَّلَاةَ وَيُنْفِقُوا مِمَّا رَزَقْنَاهُمْ سِرًّا وَعَلَانِيَةً مِنْ قَبْلِ أَنْ يَأْتِيَ يَوْمٌ لَا بَيْعٌ فِيهِ وَلَا خِلَالٌ

Say to My believing servants that they should establish the prayer and spend out of that which We have given them, secretly and openly, before the coming of the Day in which there shall be no trade, nor mutual befriending. [1]

Being charitable is one of the most emphasized actions in Islam, and is an essential part of our religion. In the Noble Qurʾān, this act is usually paired with offering prayers *(ṣalāh)*. When the Qurʾān describes the believers, it usually mentions that they are: *"those who establish prayers (ṣalāh) and give charity (zakāh)."*

We also learn from the narrations of the Ahlul Bayt ﷺ that charity has many benefits for us in our lives—both in this world and the next.

The Noble Prophet ﷺ said:

> "Give charity, and cure your sick ones through the giving of charity. Surely, charity repels accidents and illnesses, and is a source of increasing your lifespan and good deeds." [2]

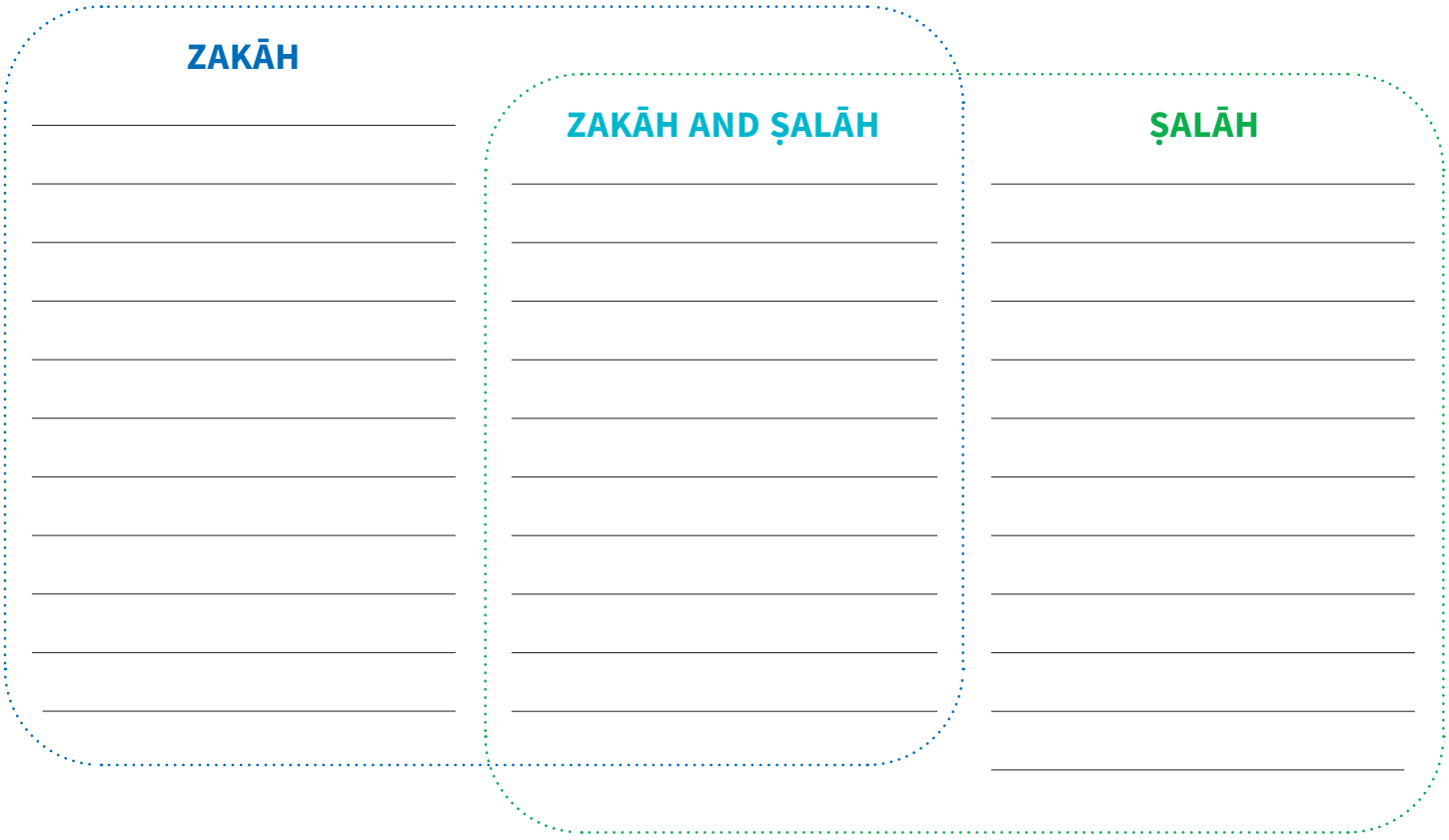
STOP AND REFLECT: What are some of the different forms of charity *(zakāh)* that you can think of? List as many as you can.



1 Noble Qurʾān, Sūrah Ibrāhīm (14), Verse 31.
2 Muttaqī Hindī, *Kanz al-ʿUmmāl*, Ḥadīth #16113.

Activity 4.2a: Benefits of Ṣalāh and Zakāh

1. Why do you think Allah ﷻ chose to pair *ṣalāh* with *zakāh*?
2. What characteristics might each of these actions instill within us? For example, *zakāh* might instill the trait of selflessness in an individual. Could *ṣalāh* do the same?
3. Besides personality and character benefits, what are some other life benefits that *ṣalāh* and *zakāh* offer, and where do these benefits or traits overlap? Complete the venn diagram below to answer the question.





ZAKĀH IN THE QURʾĀN

Zakāh is a general term that has been used in the Qurʾān for being charitable. Its literal meaning is 'purification.' In original Arabic, it was used to refer to the growth and nurturing of a tree or plant in the best way possible. The process of helping a plant grow in the best way often occurs through pruning or cutting away parts of a tree. Therefore we may learn from this that one of the ways of allowing our wealth and resources to grow in the best way is to give some of it away for the sake of Allah ﷻ. It may be that this term has been used by Allah ﷻ to teach us that when we give some of our wealth for His sake, it helps the remaining wealth that stays with us grow in a good and pure way. The Noble Qurʾān describes charity in the following ways:

A Means of Purification

خُذْ مِنْ أَمْوَالِهِمْ صَدَقَةً تُطَهِّرُهُمْ وَتُزَكِّيهِمْ بِهَا…

Take, from their possessions, (some) charity to cleanse them and purify them thereby…[3]

A Loan to Allah ﷻ

مَنْ ذَا الَّذِي يُقْرِضُ اللَّهَ قَرْضًا حَسَنًا فَيُضَاعِفَهُ لَهُ وَلَهُ أَجْرٌ كَرِيمٌ ۝

Who is there who will offer Allah a good loan so that He will multiply it for them; and they will have an excellent reward? [4]

Even though Allah ﷻ is the true Owner of everything we have, He still describes spending for His sake or in His way as a loan; and when we give this loan to Him, He promises to return it to us many times over.

Trading with Allah ﷻ

يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا هَلْ أَدُلُّكُمْ عَلَىٰ تِجَارَةٍ تُنْجِيكُمْ مِنْ عَذَابٍ أَلِيمٍ ۝ تُؤْمِنُونَ بِاللَّهِ وَرَسُولِهِ وَتُجَاهِدُونَ فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ بِأَمْوَالِكُمْ وَأَنْفُسِكُمْ ۚ ذَٰلِكُمْ خَيْرٌ لَكُمْ إِنْ كُنْتُمْ تَعْلَمُونَ ۝

O you who believe! Shall I guide you to a transaction (deal) that will save you from a painful punishment? Have faith in Allah and His Messenger, and strive in the way of Allah with your wealth and your selves. That is better for you, if you only knew. [5]

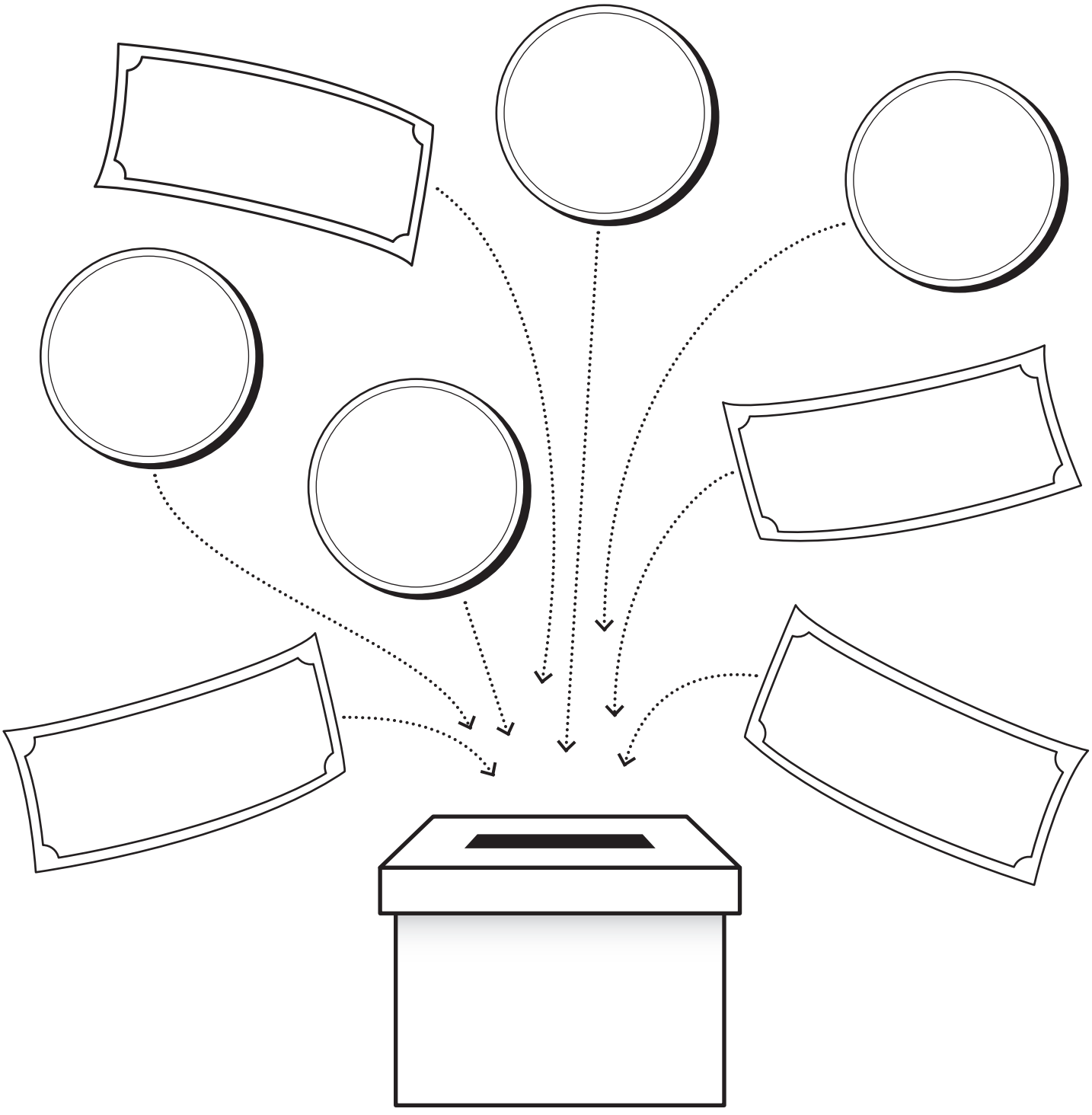
Allah ﷻ describes spending in His way as an investment. When we invest with other people, we hope to make a profit, but there is a chance that we may lose out. However, when we invest with Allah ﷻ, He guarantees that we will earn great profits.

3 Noble Qurʾān, Sūrah at-Tawbah (9), Verse 103.
4 Noble Qurʾān, Sūrah al-Ḥadīd (57), Verse 11.
5 Noble Qurʾān, Sūrah aṣ-Ṣaff (61), Verses 10-11.

Activity 4.2b: Spending for the Sake of Allah ﷻ

In what ways is spending in the way of Allah ﷻ a better way to invest our money than in worldly stock markets and investment banks? Using the graphic organizer below, brainstorm some benefits that we will receive when we spend our wealth in the way of Allah ﷻ.

THE BENEFITS OF INVESTING WITH ALLAH ﷻ





FORMS OF CHARITY

Charity can take on many forms, some of which are mentioned below:

- **TIME/EFFORT:** using our time to help a person with a certain task.
- **EDUCATION/SKILLS:** using our skills or talents to help someone who requires those specific skills; or teaching them those skills so that they can use them in the future.
- **KINDNESS:** we can help a person by listening to them, and responding with kind or helpful words.
- **FINANCIAL:** we can donate some money to those who are in need, or less fortunate than us.

Types of Financial Charity

MUSTAḤAB

ṢADAQAH that we give on a regular basis to protect ourselves from calamities and to help those in need.

GENERAL DONATIONS or other types of financial help, like spending on one's immediately family members or relatives *(khayrāt / infāq)*.

WĀJIB

KHUMS: one-fifth of our yearly savings, or on items not used for an entire year.

ZAKĀH (specific meaning): A specified percentage (for example, 2.5% or 10% or 20%) that needs to be given on specific items with certain conditions.

ZAKĀT AL-FIṬRAH: This is a wajib charity that must be given on the day of *Eid al-Fiṭr* by the breadwinner of the family for oneself, and each one of their dependents.

NADHR /ʿAHD (Conditional Promise): When a person makes a verbal promise between Allah ﷻ and oneself to give some charity under certain conditions. The promise must meet some guidelines.

QASAM (Oath): When one swears by Allah ﷻ to give a certain amount in charity.

KAFFĀRAH: A penalty that requires a person to spend from their wealth to feed the poor. Some of the reasons for having to give *kaffārah* include:

- Missing fasts, or breaking fasts in the month of Ramaḍān without a valid reason.
- Breaking one's oath/promise to Allah ﷻ.
- Violating certain conditions in Ḥa

THINK, PAIR, SHARE

1. Was there a category of charity that surprised you? Why did you find it surprising?
2. How many types of charity have you taken part in so far? What is one kind of charity that you would like to take part in soon? Why did you choose this type?

KHUMS

Having briefly reviewed the different types of charity in Islam, we will now focus on *khums*, which is a particular type of obligatory fiscal charity that Muslims must pay. It is the most common type of charity that is obligatory *(wājib)* for believers to practice. *Khums* literally means 'one-fifth' and it involves giving one-fifth (20%) of our excess or saved income at the end of one year to charity. We also need to take out *khums* on gifts or items that were not used in the first year of ownership. A person should have a date on which they calculate this type of charity. On this date, they need to calculate how much money they have saved or invested in that year (i.e., money that was left over after their ordinary expenses have been met throughout the year). From that amount, they must then pay 20% of this to a cause that is approved by their *marjaʿ*.

Khums has been expressly mentioned in the Noble Qurʾān, and was emphasized by the Ahlul Bayt ﷺ. Allah ﷻ clearly states:

وَاعْلَمُوا أَنَّمَا غَنِمْتُمْ مِنْ شَيْءٍ فَأَنَّ لِلَّهِ خُمُسَهُ وَلِلرَّسُولِ وَلِذِي الْقُرْبَىٰ وَالْيَتَامَىٰ وَالْمَسَاكِينِ وَابْنِ السَّبِيلِ...

"And Know that whatever of a thing you acquire, a fifth of it is for Allah, and for the Messenger, and for (his) near relatives, and the orphans, and the needy, and the wayfarer...." [6]





6 Noble Qurʾān, Sūrah al-Anfāl (8), Verse 41.

Activity 4.2c: Critical Analysis

Answer the following questions in depth.

1. Why do you think there is so much emphasis in Islam on giving charity?

2. What are some of the benefits for those receiving charity?

3. What are some of the benefits that those who give in charity will receive?

4. When Allah ﷻ declares that He will return a loan to us many times over, or give us multiple profits on our investments, what does this mean?

MEETING THE NEEDS OF THE BELIEVERS

As we discussed earlier, *zakāh* is not just limited to financial donations. It can take on many other forms. One of these important forms of charity is to meet the needs of our fellow Muslim brothers and sisters using whatever means we can with our time, skills, talents, or words. This is one of the most rewarding actions that can be performed.

In a famous exchange between Imām Jaʿfar aṣ-Ṣādiq ﷺ and one of his companions during a trip to *Ḥajj*, the Imām ﷺ was explaining the rewards for each of the actions in the rites of *Ḥajj*. The companion was amazed by these, and wondered at the great rewards of each action.



The Imām ﷺ then asked him: "Do you want me to teach you something that brings even greater rewards than these?"

The companion replied: "Is there such an act?"

The Imām ﷺ said: "Yes, fulfilling the need of a believer is better than (performing) one Ḥajj, and another Ḥajj, and another Ḥajj…" he continued until he counted 10 Ḥajj pilgrimages.[7]

Here, the Imām ﷺ was referring to *mustaḥab Ḥajj* after one's obligatory one is completed. After describing its great rewards, he then used the opportunity to teach us that as incredibly rewarding as *Ḥajj* is, meeting the needs of a fellow believer is even more rewarding than 10 *mustaḥab Ḥajj* trips.

In another narration, the Prophet ﷺ compares the reward of meeting the needs of a fellow believer to *iʿtikāf*. *Iʿtikāf* is a ritual in which a person secludes oneself from the world by staying in a Masjid and engaging in worship for at least a minimum of three consecutive days. As you can imagine, this is a highly rewarding act! The Prophet ﷺ said:

> "Walking with a fellow believer to help them in their need is dearer to Allah than performing iʿtikāf in Masjid Al-Ḥarām (in Mecca) for two months." [8]

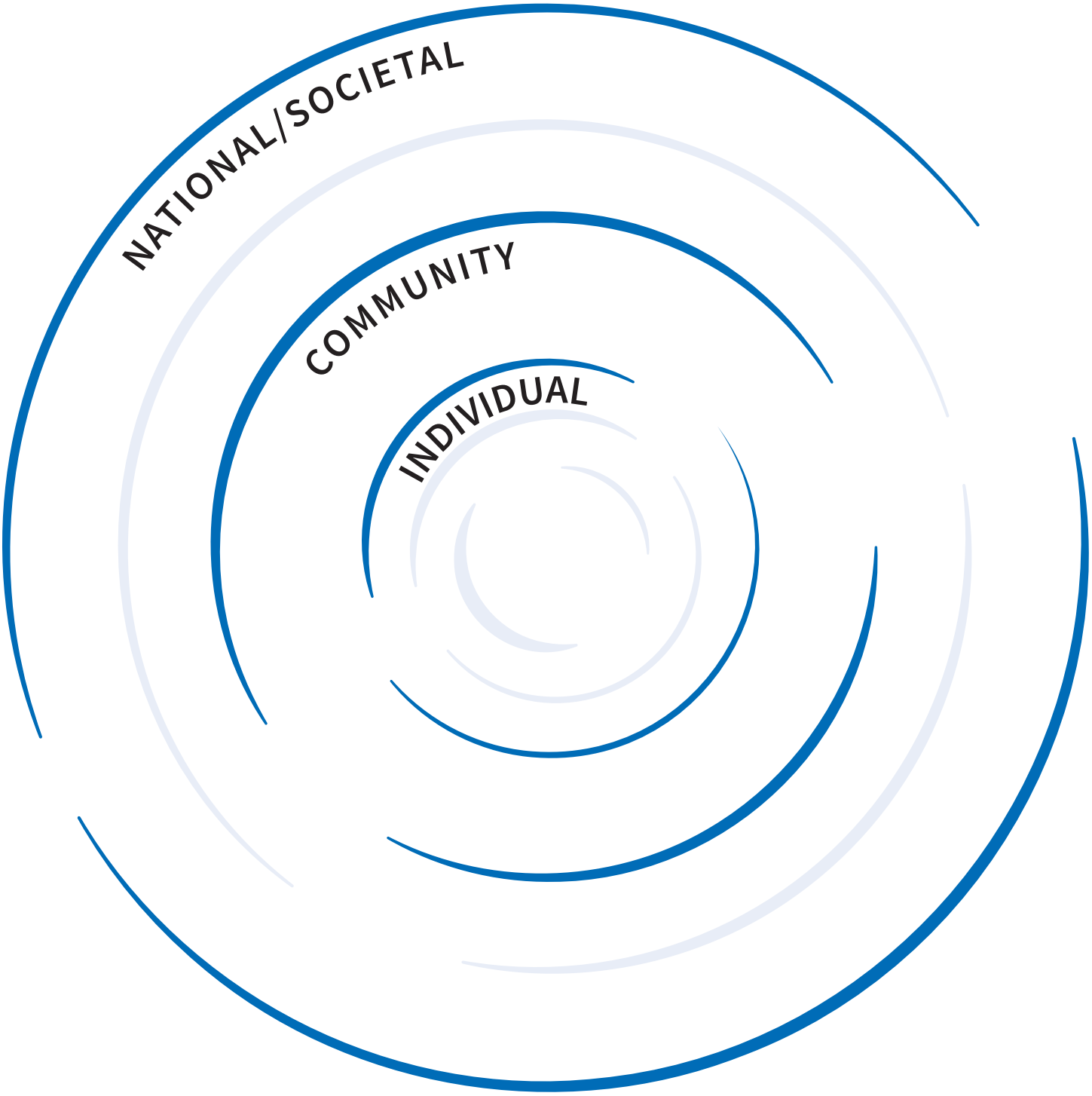
IʿTIKĀF: a ritual in which one secludes themselves from the world by staying in a masjid and engaging in worship for at least three consecutive days

7 Shaykh Ṣadūq, *Al-Amālī*, P. 801, Ḥadīth #582.
8 Muḥaddith Nūrī, *Mustadrak al-Wasāʾil*, Vol. 12, P. 412.

Activity 4.2d: A Ripple Effect of Social Benefits

1. Why is meeting the needs of fellow believers given such importance in Islam?

2. What are some of the benefits of giving in charity on an individual, community, and national/societal scale?



BRINGING BENEFIT AND HAPPINESS TO PEOPLE



Another important form of charity in Islam is to bring about benefit to people. This extends even to simply bringing happiness to them through a kind word or gesture.

Imām aṣ-Ṣādiq ﷺ quotes the Messenger of Allah ﷺ as having said: "The creations are the dependents of Allah. The most beloved (of the servants of Allah) are those who bring the most benefit to them (other dependents), and who help them in their needs." [9]

REPELLING HARM FROM PEOPLE



Something as simple as removing harm or garbage from the path of people is considered a form of charity in Islam. Imām Ḥasan al-ʿAskarī ﷺ quotes the Prophet ﷺ as having said: "Charity is obligatory upon all Muslims every day. When the Prophet ﷺ said this, he was asked: 'Who can afford to pay charity every single day?' He ﷺ responded: 'Even removing harm from the path of believers is charity.'" [10]

A more advanced form of this type of charity is to reach a level of expertise in a field of science or technology that removes major harm from people. This may include things like researching a particular disease and finding a cure or prevention for it; or studying natural phenomena such as fires or floods, and developing strategies for reducing the risk factors from these natural occurrences.



It has been narrated from Imām as-Sajjād ﷺ, from his father Imām Ḥusayn ﷺ that the Messenger ﷺ of Allah ﷺ said:

> "Whoever repels from the Muslim community a flood or a fire, Paradise becomes obligatory for them." [11]



Activity 4.2e: Benefits and Harms: Role-Playing

As was mentioned in this lesson, providing benefits to or removing harms from the paths of people is considered an important form of charity in Islam. Working with partners or in a group, come up with a scenario in which a benefit is provided to another person. Then, think of a scenario where an act of charity is performed by removing harm from the path of other people. Share your role-playing skits with the class.

9 Shaykh Kulaynī, *Al-Kāfī*, Vol. 2, P. 199.
10 *Mustadrak al-Wasā'il*, Vol. 7, P. 242.
11 *Al-Kāfī*, Vol. 5, P. 55.